DISI

Silk for gen z

Problem Statement

Despite India being one of the world's largest producers of authentic silk, the present generation especially Gen Z has minimal engagement with pure silk products. For younger consumers, silk is largely perceived as expensive, heavy, occasion specific, and culturally restricted to traditional garments such as silk sarees, which are often worn only for weddings or formal events.

This narrow association has resulted in:

- Low everyday usage of authentic silk among youth.
- A growing disconnect between traditional silk industries and modern fashion consumption.
- Reduced awareness of the craft, sustainability, and cultural value of silk.
- Younger consumers opting for cheaper synthetic alternatives that lack longevity and authenticity.

As a result, authentic silk is gradually losing relevance in the daily lives of the present generation, threatening both the future consumer base and the sustainability of traditional silk industries.

Design Opportunity

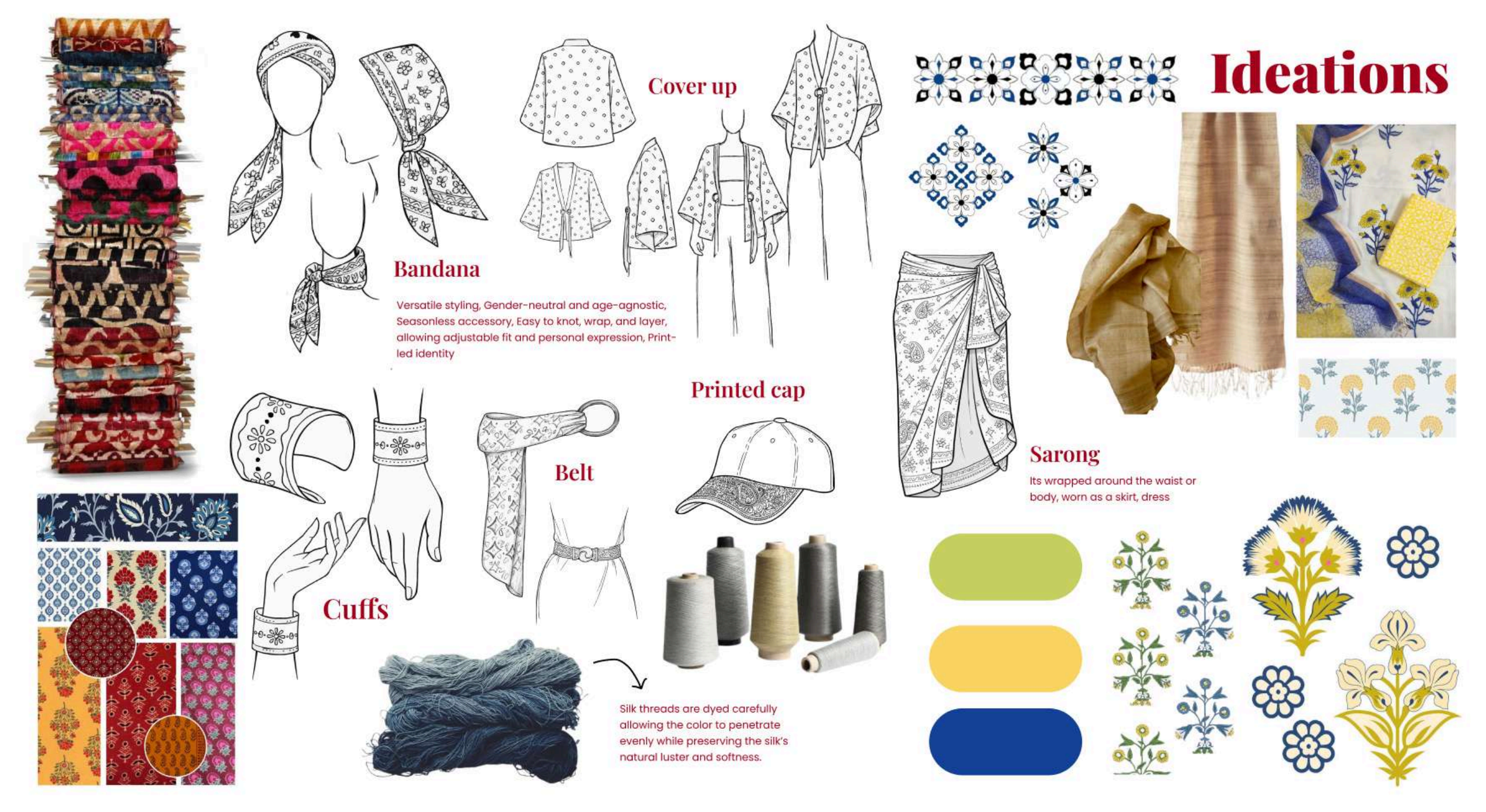
The problem is not a lack of appreciation for silk, but a lack of relatable, affordable, and contemporary silk products that fit the lifestyle and aesthetic preferences of the younger generation.

Trend Research

Gen Z consumers prioritize self-expression over traditional markers of status, valuing individuality and authenticity above overt luxury. Comfort and ease of wear consistently outweigh the appeal of formality or opulence. There is a strong inclination toward **versatile, gender-fluid, and modular clothing, with silhouettes** that are layered, breathable, and adaptable—often featuring wrap, tie, or adjustable elements that allow personal styling.

Within this context, silk can be repositioned not as an occasion-bound or ceremonial material, but as a form of **slow, understated luxury—quiet, tactile, and deeply intentional**. This marks a deliberate shift away from the conventional framing of silk as "wedding-only" attire, toward everyday relevance rooted in comfort, longevity, and expressive design.

Breathable wear
Deconstructed silhouettes
Gender fluid looks


Cover up
Ideations
Bandana
Versatile styling, Gender-neutral and age-agnostic, Seasonless accessory, Easy to knot, wrap, and layer, allowing adjustable fit and personal expression, Print-led identity
Printed cap
Belt
Cuffs
Sarong
Its wrapped around the waist or body, worn as a skirt, dress
Silk threads are dyed carefully allowing the color to penetrate evenly while preserving the silk's natural luster and softness.

Business model

Business models suitable for social enterprises

A social enterprise addresses social problems through sustainable business activities, combining economic viability with social impact to enable long-term, self-sustaining community development.

Social Franchise Model

In this model, a successful social enterprise replicates its operations across regions through a franchise-like structure, maintaining core values while allowing local adaptation.

Key characteristics
- Replicable framework
- Standardized social impact goals
- Localised execution

NGO-Led Social Enterprise Model

Here, a non-governmental organization initiates or supports income-generating activities to address a specific social issue. Revenue may come from product sales, grants, or donations, and is primarily used to fund social objectives.

Key characteristics:
- Social mission-led operations
- External funding or grants often required
- Focus on capacity building and welfare

REWOVEN

January 2026

SPUN: A GEN-Z TAKE ON SILK

NOT YOUR

NAANI'S SILK

UN-THREADING TRADITION

OUR SOLUTION

Instead of focusing on large traditional garments like sarees, this strategy reimagines silk in smaller, everyday products such as scarves, bandanas, caps, bracelets, belts, and lightweight tops or short kurtis. Using less silk makes the products more affordable, versatile, and suitable for daily or semi-casual wear, positioning silk as a practical part of everyday fashion rather than an occasional luxury.

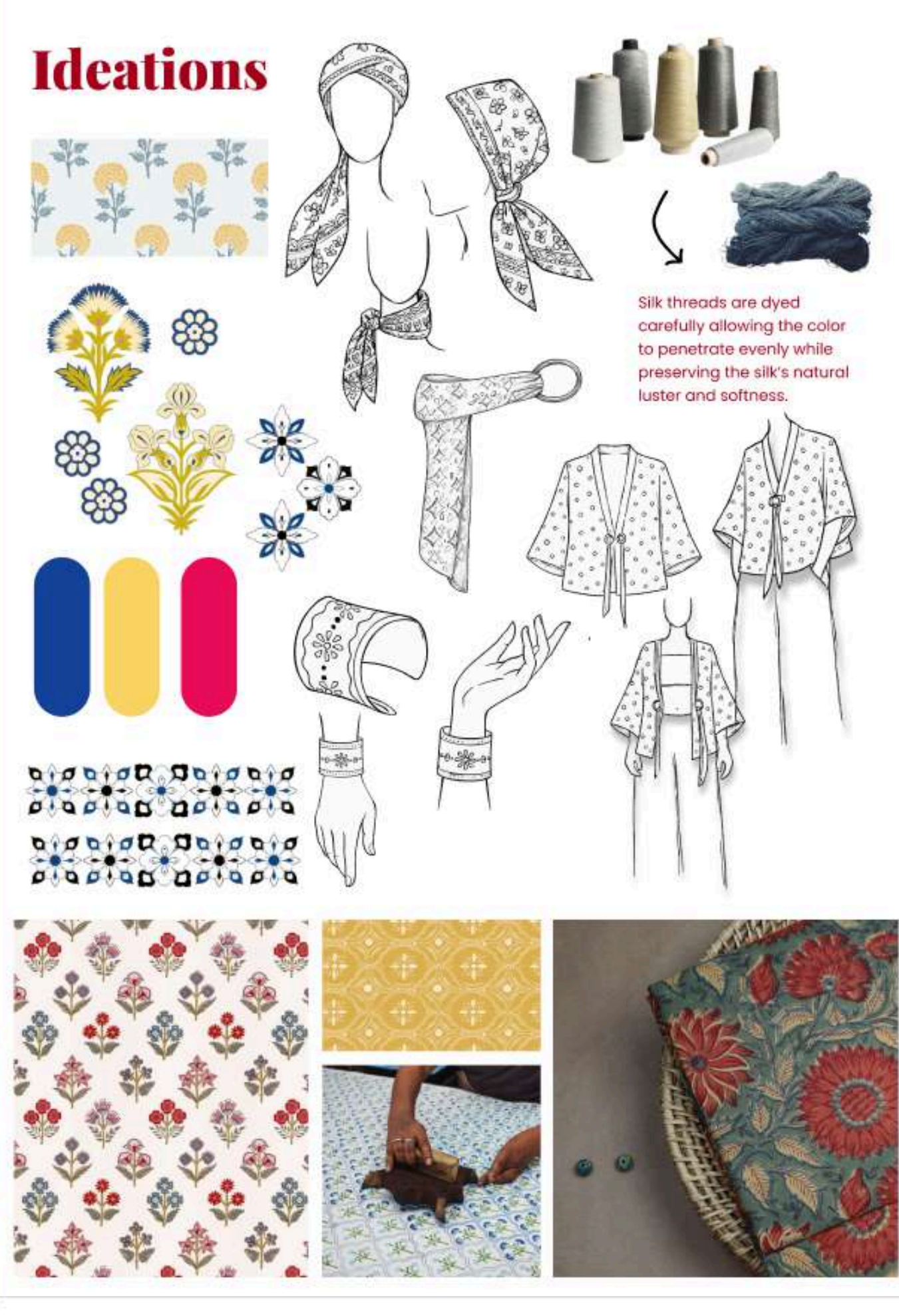
The design blends traditional craft with a modern aesthetic to appeal to Gen Z audiences. Block printing is used as the core technique, with simplified and abstracted motifs paired with contemporary color palettes. This keeps the products culturally rooted while making them fresh, lightweight, and aligned with current fashion trends.

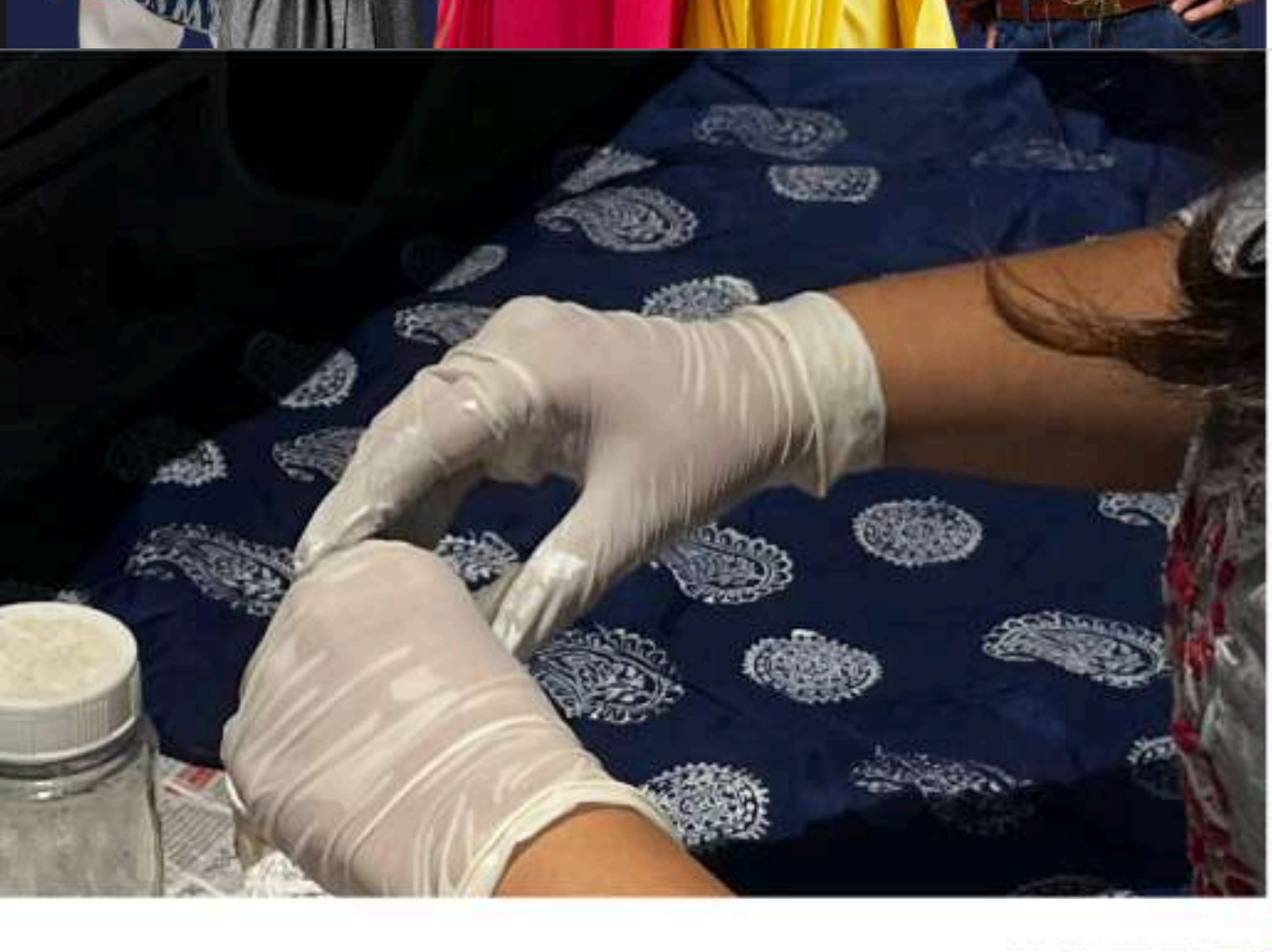
THE PROCESS

TREND RESEARCH

Gen Z fashion is defined by a shift away from traditional luxury towards comfort, self-expression, and sustainability. This generation values versatile, gender-neutral clothing that allows for flexibility and ease. They prioritize eco-conscious brands, often opting for natural fibers, recycled materials, and ethical production processes. This generation is actively pushing back against fast fashion, demanding more transparency in sourcing and production. With an increasing interest in second-hand shopping and upcycled clothing, Gen Z is reshaping the fashion industry to reflect values of durability and ethical consumption, making sustainability a key factor in their buying decisions. Trends like Y2K fashion, 90s throwback styles, and vintage-inspired designs are making a comeback, yet always with a twist that reflects contemporary attitudes. Digital culture plays a huge role, with TikTok and Instagram shaping their style preferences, driving microtrends, and encouraging rapid visual experimentation

Clothes are no longer costumes they're conversations.


Ideations
Silk threads are dyed carefully allowing the color to penetrate evenly while preserving the silk's natural luster and softness.



Applications of the Printed Silk Cloth

Garments

The block-printed silk cloth was explored across multiple contemporary silhouettes:
Skirts that emphasize fluidity and movement while remaining lightweight and comfortable
Kurtis that blend traditional silhouettes with modern styling, making silk suitable for everyday wear
Tops designed to be minimal, breathable, and versatile, appealing to a younger audience
These garments demonstrate how silk can be adapted beyond festive or ceremonial use and integrated into daily wardrobes.

Accessories

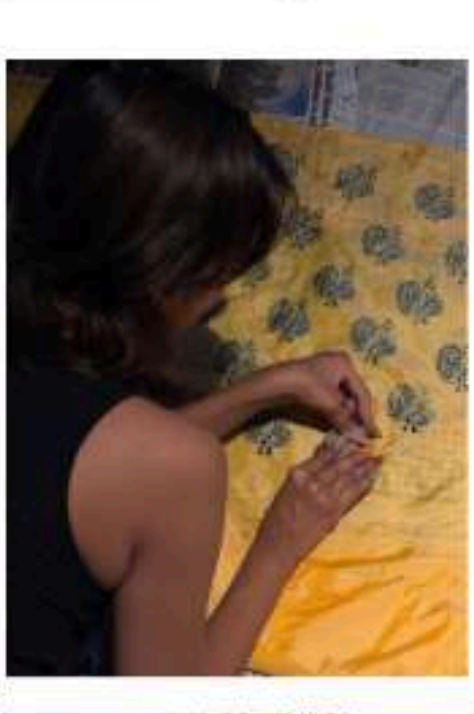
To further expand the usability of silk, leftover and printed fabric was also transformed into fabric bangles. By structuring the silk into accessories, the material was reimagined in a non-garment form, making it more approachable, playful, and functional. This also encouraged minimal waste and maximum material utilization.

Material Sourcing: Silk Cloth

Based on our observations, we visited a silk outlet to source pure silk cloth. The focus was on selecting fabric that was lightweight, breathable, and suitable for reinterpretation into everyday wear rather than occasion-specific garments. The intent was to move silk away from its conventional association with heavy, formal attire and explore its potential as a versatile material.

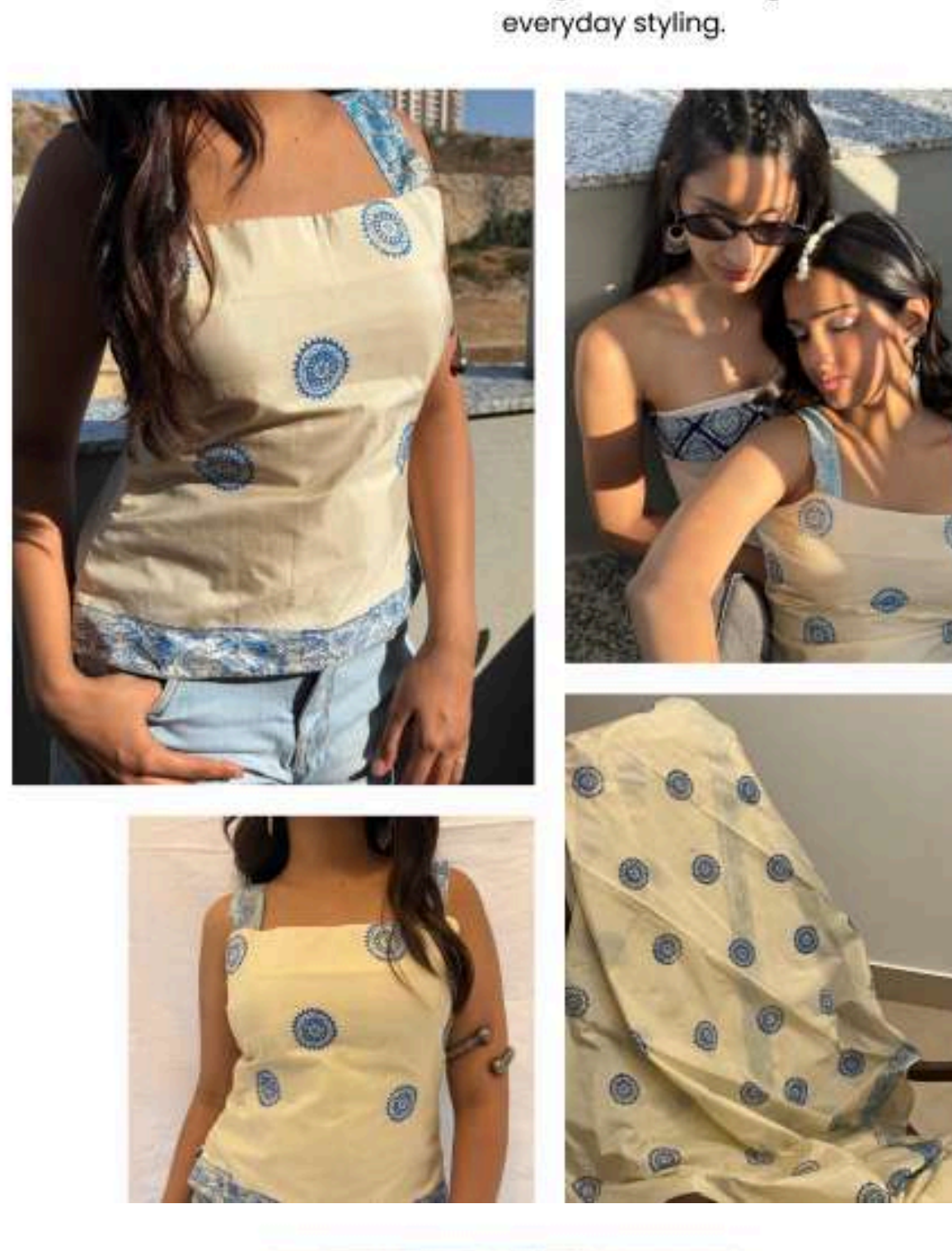
Surface Design: Block Printing

To retain the essence of traditional textile craft, we chose block printing as the surface design technique. Wooden blocks were sourced and dyes were selected to achieve rich yet wearable color palettes. The silk cloth was then manually block-printed, allowing each piece to carry slight variations that highlight the handcrafted process and individuality of the fabric.

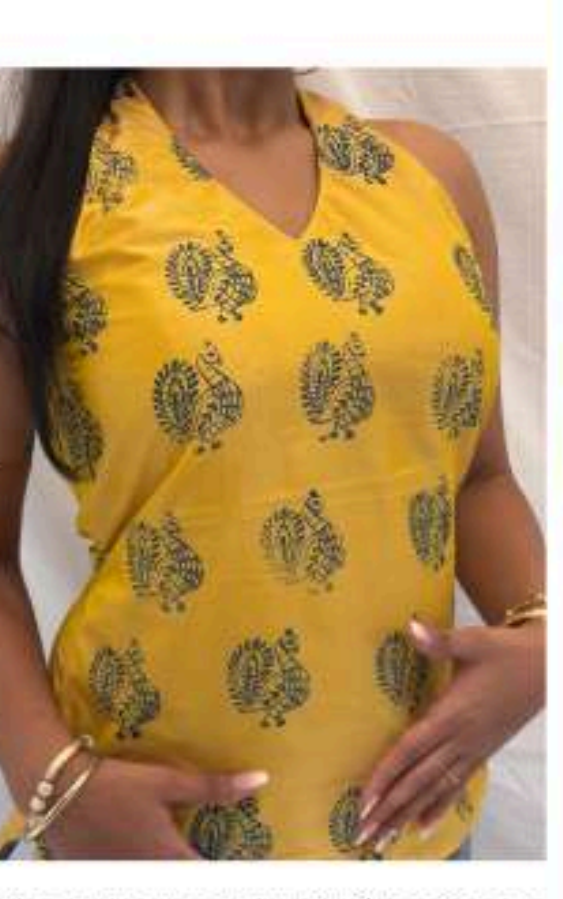


Block Printed Silk Top

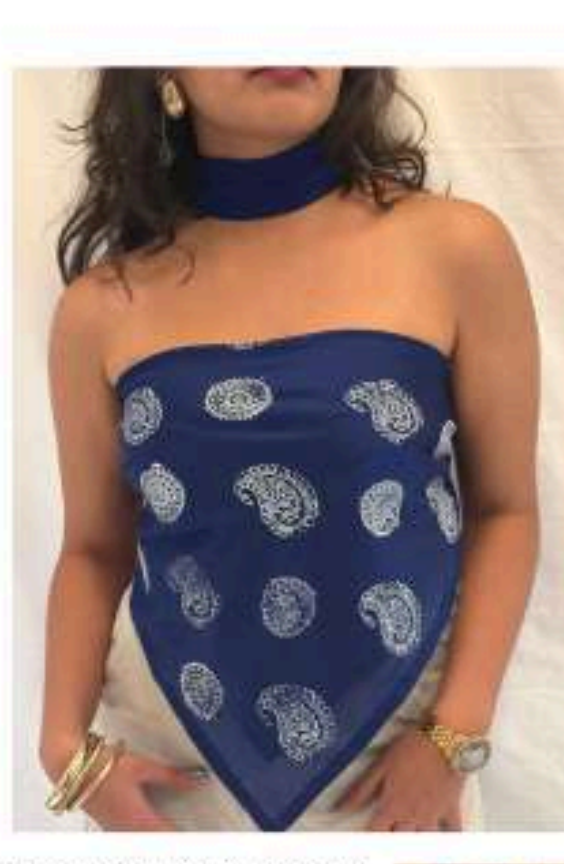
The first design is a structured silk top featuring evenly spaced block-printed motifs. The simplicity of the silhouette allows the print to stand out while making silk feel casual and wearable. The contrast border detail adds definition and frames the garment, making it suitable for everyday styling.



Halter Neck Kurti



The halter neck kurti reimagines a traditional Indian garment through a modern neckline. The block-printed motifs add cultural depth, while the halter style gives it a fresh and experimental edge. This design bridges ethnic wear and modern fashion seamlessly.

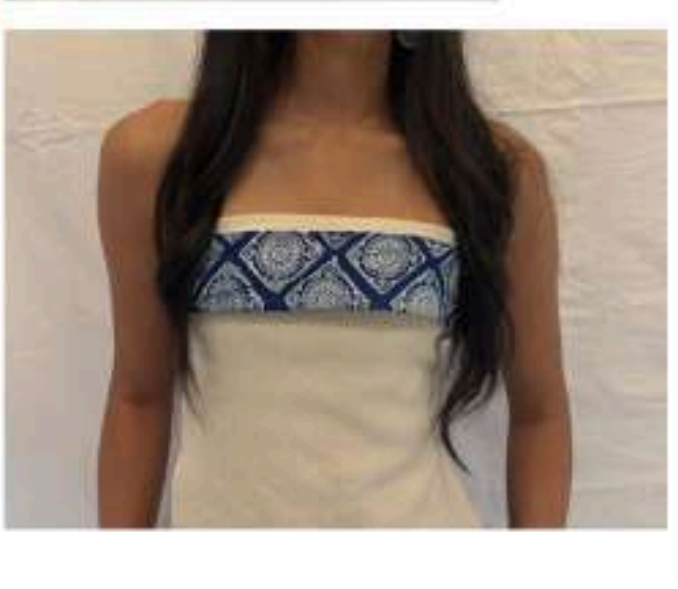


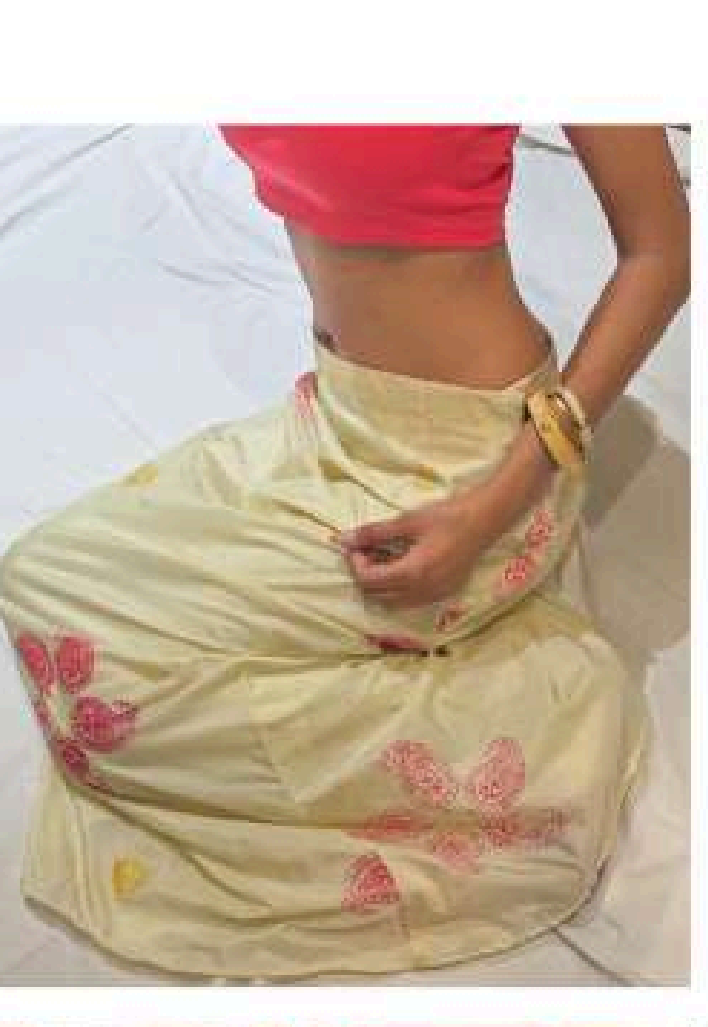
The bandeau top presents silk in a bold, minimal form. The block-printed motifs are spread across the fabric, while the strapless silhouette gives it a modern, youthful appeal. This design breaks the stereotype of silk being formal and shows its adaptability to western, Gen-Z fashion.

Bandeau Top

Block Printed Border on Regular Top

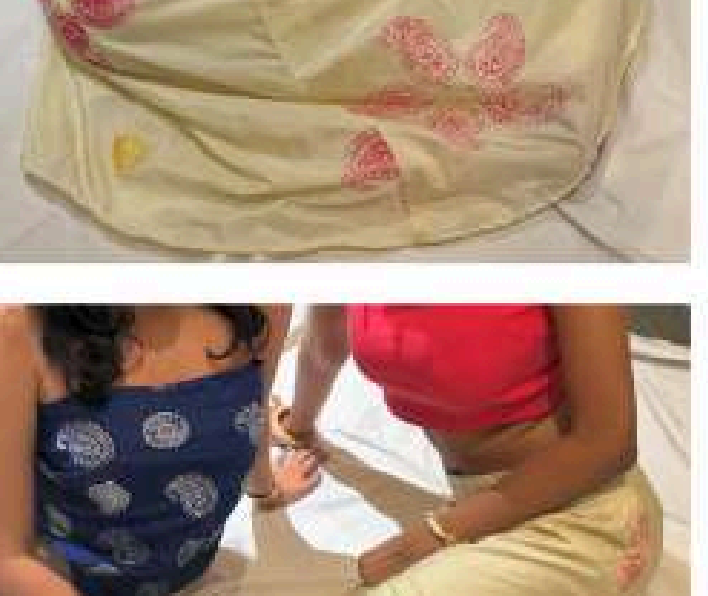
The final piece focuses on detailing rather than full coverage printing. A block-printed silk border is added to a regular top, subtly elevating the garment. This approach demonstrates how silk can be incorporated in small elements to modernize everyday clothing without overpowering it.

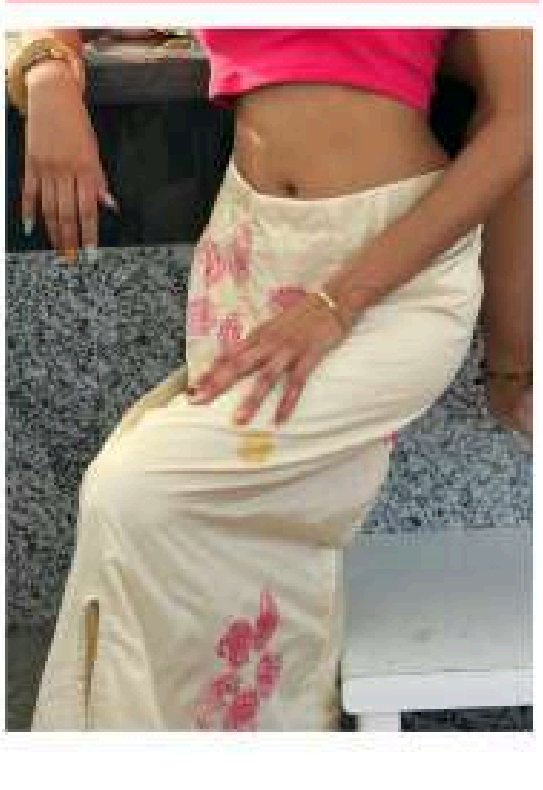


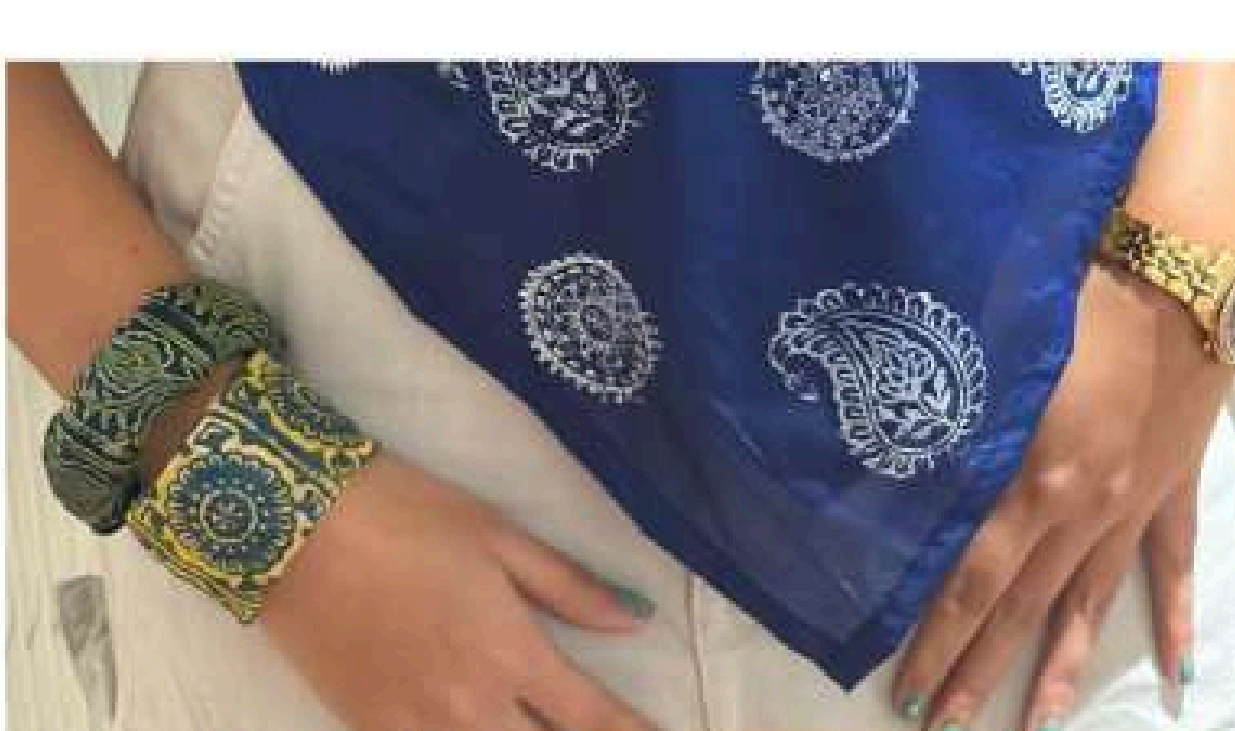


Fish Line Skirt

The fish line skirt highlights movement and flow, using silk's natural drape to enhance the silhouette. The block prints are placed thoughtfully so they remain visible while the skirt flares, adding visual interest with every movement. This piece blends traditional craftsmanship with a contemporary cut.







Bangles & Belts

These pieces are handcrafted using silk fabric, block-printed with traditional motifs and re-imagined as contemporary accessories.